replace them with the MINT (Mexico, Indonesia, Nigeria and Turkey), which are seen as candidates for financial speculation. In reality, potential recipients for these funds are as numerous as they are fleeting. Other recently named candidates include: Vietnam, Australia, Bangladesh, Chile, Colombia, South Korea, Egypt, the Philippines, Iran, Israel, Malaysia, Mexico, Nigeria, Pakistan, Peru, Poland, the Czech Republic, Singapore and Thailand. As there are no criteria for classifying such a wide variety of countries, the alphabet soup only multiplies (CIVETS, EAGLES, AEM, VISTA, MAVINS). It should be clear that all this terminological double talk does nothing to clarify any economic processes. Based on some financial similarity, medium-sized and peripheral or industrialised and rentier states are all mixed together.

Semi-peripheral economies

The expected increase in US interest rates has already reduced the BRICS' breathing space. Some economists consider the greatest risks in the next financial panic will be displaced onto the intermediate economies, which have higher fiscal deficits and lower growth rates.[7] Others fear a repetition of the terrible crises that similar economies fell into during the 1990s (Mexico 1994, Southeast Asia 1997, Russia 1998, or Argentina 2001). But beyond this conjunctural diagnosis, it is important to remember that the division within the old bloc of non-industrialised nations has deepened. One segment has improved its weak economic infrastructure by developing manufactured exports, integrating businesses into the circuits of international corporations, or growing productive services. The other sector retains, in turn, its old raw materials profile.

The classification of economies by their structure and their insertion into the international division of labour is favoured by authors who are critical of the vague concept of 'emerging' economies. Flowing from an analysis centred on the global productive process, these authors have clarified the content of the notion of the 'semi-periphery'.[8] This category applies to countries such as Korea, Taiwan, Turkey, Mexico, Brazil and South Africa, which have distanced themselves from the bulk of the Asian, African or Latin American periphery. This intermediate position supports the idea of a tri-polar order postulated by world systems theorists and their characterisation of the semi-periphery as a segment which serves as a buffer between the two poles of global capitalism.[9] This group is currently playing a leading role in creating the bifurcation that traditionally separates the emerging economies from their underdeveloped peers. This is how the trajectory followed by countries which, through contradictory periods, cross over from proximity to the centre to convergence with the periphery, is repeated.